

LIGHT OPERA or MUSICAL COMEDY is a play set to music in which part of the dialogue is sung and part of it spoken. Such works usually have a happy ending. "Fra Diavolo" (Brother Devil) which derives its name from the hero, a famous Italian bandit, is a comic opera in 3 acts; music by the French composer, Daniel François Esprit Auber. It was first given in Paris in 1830.



Fra Diavolo as the Marquis—Act I

Zerlina, an innkeeper's daughter is betrothed to Lorenzo, a soldier, but they are too poor to marry. Fra Diavolo, disguised as the Marquis San Marco, is travelling with two English tourists, Lord and Lady Allcash, in order to rob them of money and jewels. When the party arrives at the inn and tells of an attempted robbery by highwaymen, Zerlina, believing Fra Diavolo to be a real marquis, tells him the story of this bold bandit's life in the aria (solo) "On Yonder Rock Reclining". That night, after the guests retire, the marquis (Fra Diavolo) with several of his followers, conceals himself in Zerlina's room to rob Lord Allcash. Lorenzo, who has been ordered to pursue the bandits, arrives with a party of soldiers and arrests two of the robbers while Fra Diavolo escapes to the mountains. In the third act, he is captured. Lorenzo receives a handsome reward, marries Zerlina, and they live happily ever afterwards.

Always
Be
Careful

On Yonder Rock Reclining

to pass the thumb under smoothly

Allegretto

D. F. E. Auber (1782-1821)